opponent, and the Nazis falsely claimed he was Jewish. In 1936, the Austrian government denied Schlick a travel visa to attend the conference in Copenhagen at Bohr's house. On the morning of the first full day of the conference, while Bohr and Frank were presenting papers in Copenhagen, Schlick was approached by a former student, Johann Nelböck, on the steps of the University of Vienna. Nelböck shot Schlick four times at point-blank range; he died on the spot. Nelböck was apprehended, confessed, and found to be of sound mind, but the Austrian Nazis took up his cause and distorted the facts of the case in the Viennese press. Nelböck was sentenced to a mere ten years in prison for murder. When Austria became part of Nazi Germany in the Anschluss of 1938, Nelböck applied for a pardon, stating in his application (where he referred to himself in the third person) "that by his act and the resulting elimination of a Jewish teacher who propagated doctrines alien and detrimental to the nation he rendered National Socialism a service and also suffered for National Socialism as a consequence of his act." The Nazis pardoned him after he had served only two years of his sentence.

By the time war broke out in 1939, the only core member of the Vienna Circle still living in continental Europe was Otto Neurath. After the fascists took over Austria, he had fled to the Netherlands, hoping to continue his internationally minded work from The Hague. In 1940, he and his assistant managed to escape to England in a boat while Rotterdam burned, hours before the Nazis arrived in The Hague. After the war, there were attempts to reorganize the circle, but Neurath's sudden death in December 1945 largely put an end to those efforts. Positivism continued on as a philosophy under the new name "logical empiricism," but the Vienna Circle's grand dream of an organized political, philosophical, and scientific movement was dead.

Any remaining hope of reviving a unified movement around positivism was dashed by the postwar political environment in the United States. Anticommunist hysteria in the United States rose sharply after World War II, and the nascent Cold War had chilling effects on all arenas of intellectual discourse, including philosophy. To some, the Unity of Science movement, with its left-wing politics, its antireligious philosophy, and its internationalist aspirations, sounded suspiciously like a Communist Party front. During the "red scare" that effectively exiled David Bohm, J. Edgar Hoover's FBI compiled dossiers on Carnap, Frank, and other leading positivist lights. Under enormous pressure to refrain from all political